THE LETTERS OF THE RAMBAM

How Dare You Condemn Them? The Rambam's Letter on Martyrdom, Part 1

The Letters of the Rambam (2025)

Source: Igrot HaRambam: *Iggeret HaShmad* / *Ma'amar Kiddush Hashem* (written in Arabic in the Rambam's twenties; read in Hebrew translation)

Shiur: Fifth class in the series on the Rambam's letters, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 25 February 2025

These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording.

Introduction

So far the letters have gone to **Israel** (Ovadia), **France** (astrology) and **Iraq** (Ibn Jabbar), "so you see how the Rambam is spread out." This, **the longest so far**, will take two or three sessions. "This letter is a complete and absolute treasure."

Two names

The Rambam gave it no title. Two 14th-century Spanish Rishonim name it differently:

	Name
Rivash (Rabbi Yitzchak bar Sheshet)	**אגרת השמד**: the letter on *shmad*, decrees forcing Jews to abandon their religion
Tashbetz (Rabbi Shimon ben Tzemach Duran, Spain and later Algeria)	**מאמר קידוש השם**: the essay on sanctifying Hashem's name

When was it written?

Probably the Rambam's first known letter, written **under 30**, and the Rabbi thinks in his **early twenties**, while he was **himself living through the persecution** (the Almohad *shmad*, which affected most Jewish communities of the time).

His years of wandering (approximate dates, per Rav Shilat):

Year	Age	
1138	0	Born in **Córdoba**
~1160	~22	To **Fez, Morocco**, because of persecution
~1161	23	Begins the **Commentary on the Mishnah**
~1165	~27	A few months in **Israel**; "it didn't work out"
1166		**Egypt**
1168	30	Completes the Commentary in Egypt

- In the **Letter to Yemen**: *how could I be exact in halacha, exiled from city to city, kingdom to kingdom?*
- At the end of the **Commentary on the Mishnah**: Hashem decreed exile for him "from one end of the earth to the other," and he wrote **parts of it on board ship**.
- Egypt had no such decree, so the letter predates it.

"To write with this confidence, clarity, precision, wisdom, **and sarcasm** at such an age is astonishing." This sharpness we don't see later in his life.

Language: almost certainly written in **Arabic**. The Hebrew we have is **less precise** than the Rambam's usual perfect Hebrew, "the kind of Hebrew we find in his European counterparts, the Tosafists." The translator wasn't the best.

The question

Someone forced to **declare that Muhammad is a true prophet**: should he say it **to save his life**, though it may lead to his children **assimilating** among the Muslims and to **abandoning the mitzvot**? Or should he **die** rather than say it?

He had asked another rabbi (identity unknown), didn't like the answer, and sent it to the Rambam. **"Remarkably, the majority of this letter is devoted to dismantling the previous rabbi's answer"**; the Rambam's own ruling comes at the end.

Part 1: "A Weak, Tasteless Answer"

שאל איש מאנשי דורנו לאיש מאנשי החכמה לפי דבריו: someone of our generation asked a man who, **by his own account**, is wise...

...**someone who never experienced the persecution** (may Hashem annul it). Had he lived it, he'd never have answered as he did.

ויען הנשאל על זה דבר חלוש אין לו טעם: he gave a **weak answer with no flavour**, rambling, which would **mislead even people lacking sense**.

(The original comparison is to women. The Rabbi notes it reflects the Rambam's time, when women were far less educated than men.)

Why the Rambam won't quote it all

I'd quote the bulk of it, long and weak as it is, but **Hashem has given us the gift of speech**: **מי שם פה לאדם**. So **a person should be more sparing with his words than with his money.** Don't say much with little content.

- **Kohelet: כי בא החלום ברוב עניין, וקול כסיל ברוב דברים**: a fool is known by many words.
- **Iyov's friends: הרוב דברים לא ייענה?**, "will a multitude of words be answered?"; **איוב לא בדעת ידבר**.

"We're very careful how we spend money. We should be at least as careful with our words."

Part 2: The Rabbi's Errors

	The rabbi said	The Rambam's reply
1	Acknowledging Muhammad is **denying God**: **כל המודה בעבודה זרה כאילו כפר בכל התורה כולה**	**Can't he tell the difference** between acknowledging idolatry **willingly**, like **Yeravam** and his followers, and saying someone is a prophet **out of fear of the sword**?
2	Whoever says it is **a gentile**, even if he keeps the whole Torah **in public and in private**	Is there no difference between one who doesn't keep **Shabbat because of the sword** and one who doesn't **by choice**?
3	If such a man enters their **house of prayer** (even saying nothing) and then prays in a **synagogue**, his prayer is a **sin** (Yirmeyahu: **שתיים רעות עשה עמי**, serving idols one day and coming to the Temple the next)	Yirmeyahu condemned **willing** idolaters. This man **sits** in a mosque under duress and then goes to shul. You call his prayer a sin?
4	He's a **rasha**, **invalid as a witness**	Calling him wicked is the core outrage
5	**Even the Christians** agree one should die rather than acknowledge Muhammad	"**I was astonished.** Have we no Torah, that we need proofs from **Christians**? And if the nations offer their children to their gods, should we?" "**Woe** that such a question must be asked, and woe to one who answers so."

"I said I wouldn't judge him till I'd heard all his words": **משיב דבר בטרם ישמע, אוולת היא לו**. Perhaps, as Shlomo said, **טוב אחרית דבר מראשיתו**, the end would be better than the beginning. **It wasn't.** "The beginning of his words is folly, and the end is worse."

Part 3: Prepare Before You Speak, and More Before You Write

Never speak in public until you've gone over your words four times.

The Midrash learns it from **אז ראה ויספרה, הכינה וגם חקרה**: four expressions of preparation before Hashem "spoke" the Torah.

"If only everyone who gets up to speak would prepare four times. **Maybe once before would be good!**"

And what you put in writing, to be copied and passed around, you should check **a thousand times**, if that were possible.

People give the written word **more credence** (as we keep seeing in these letters). This rabbi wrote **once**, sure of himself, and **disseminated it unfinished**: "he has spread darkness."

Part 4: Speaking Ill of Israel: Four Who Were Punished

"The fundamental mistake underlying everything he wrote": **condemning Jewish communities.**

1. Moshe: "They won't believe me"

In Egypt, Israel was at its lowest:

- **Only the tribe of Levi** circumcised. When the **korban Pesach** required milah, **Moshe circumcised, Yehoshua performed *peri'ah and Aharon metzitzah***, until the **blood of milah mixed with the blood of the Pesach**: **בדמייך חיי**.

- They were steeped in forbidden relationships (a man marrying two sisters, and more), "the 49th level of impurity."

Yet when Moshe said **והן לא יאמינו לי**, "they won't believe me," Hashem rebuked him: **הן מאמינים בני מאמינים**, "they are believers, children of believers. **You** will not believe in the end" (at the rock). **And he was punished at once**: his hand turned **white with tzara'at**. The Gemara: **החושד בכשרים לוקה בגופו**.

2. Eliyahu: "Israel has forsaken Your covenant"

All of Israel but **7,000** served Ba'al. Eliyahu said **קנא קנאתי... כי עזבו בריתך בני ישראל**: "surely he was right?" The **Midrash (Chazit, on Shir HaShirim)**: Is it **your** covenant? *They've torn down Your altars.* Are they **your** altars? *They've killed Your prophets.* **And you're still alive.** Look at the nations: they build great temples to idols; why come to accuse **My** people?

3. Yeshayahu: "A people of impure lips"

In Yeshayahu's time they had **mezuzot on their doors and idols inside**, murder, **אכול ושתו כי מחר נמות**: "eat and drink, for tomorrow we die." Yet when he said **בתוך עם טמא שפתיים אנכי יושב**, "I dwell among a people of impure lips," **the seraph touched his mouth with a burning coal**. The Rabbi adds the tradition that his sin was fully atoned only when **Menasheh** killed him.

4. The angel against Yehoshua the Kohen Gadol

When the **Satan** accused **Yehoshua** (whose sons had married improper wives), Hashem said **יגער ה' בך השטן**: "Hashem rebuke you, Satan!"

If **the pillars of the world** (Moshe, Eliyahu, Yeshayahu, the ministering angels) were punished **for a small thing**, perhaps justified, about people who sinned **willingly** (idolatry, murder, adultery), how dare **this man** call **whole communities** sinners, wicked, gentiles, unfit witnesses and deniers of God, **people who did nothing willingly, only under persecution?**

Does he not know that Hashem never abandons those who sin under duress? When Yitzchak smelled Yaakov's clothes (**וירח את ריח בגדיו**), the Sages read **בגדיו** as **בוגדיו**, his *traitors*: **even our betrayers** smell sweet to Hashem.

"The Rambam hasn't yet said whether it's *right* to acknowledge Muhammad. He's talking **after the fact**: if you did it, Hashem won't abandon you."

Part 5: The Sages Who Pretended

Rabbi Meir

Caught in a persecution: **"You're Meir!"** "No, I'm not Jewish." "Then eat this": **pork**. He got away by **pretending to eat** without eating (Avodah Zarah 18b). "You might think: eating pork isn't one of the three cardinal sins, so he didn't need to die. **It's not so simple**; in that situation, halachically, he'd have had to give his life." **By this rabbi's logic, Rabbi Meir is a gentile.** He pretended to be a non-Jew in public and was a Jew in private, exactly what the rabbi said makes you a gentile.

Rabbi Eliezer

Arrested for **minut** (heresy), worse than idolatry: a Sefer Torah written by an idolater is merely unusable, but one written by a **min** must be **burned**. The governor: *How can a man as wise as you waste his time on this religion?* Rabbi Eliezer answered: **נאמן עלי הדיין**, "**The Judge** is trustworthy to me" (Avodah Zarah 16b). The governor took it as *you* are right; Rabbi Eliezer meant **Hashem**. "**Dimissus**, you're released."

He let the official believe he agreed **with heresy**, worse than idolatry, while his heart was with Hashem. **By this rabbi's logic, Rabbi Eliezer is invalid.**

What's being demanded now

In this persecution no one asks us to serve an idol, to bow to Jesus or an image. They only want us to **say** we believe Muhammad is a true prophet, **and they know we don't believe it.**

Nebuchadnezzar's Babylon

In Babylon all but **Chananyah, Mishael and Azaryah** bowed to the image, "even the sages." **No one ever called them wicked, and Hashem never counted it as idolatry, because they were forced.**

The Midrash on Esther: **they served idols only outwardly, so I acted toward them only outwardly**. Haman's decree *looked* like destruction, but inwardly Hashem had a plan. So by this rabbi's logic, he is **criticising Hashem**.

The Greeks

One of the Greek decrees: Jews **could not lock their doors**, so they couldn't secretly keep mitzvot. Publicly they acted like Greeks; secretly, when they could, they kept the mitzvot. **Hashem never condemned them; the Sages called them righteous** and instituted prayers for them. "I didn't know this, actually."

Summary

1. The letter (*Iggeret HaShmad* / *Ma'amar Kiddush Hashem*), probably the Rambam's first, written in his twenties **under persecution**.
2. The question: **declare Muhammad a prophet to live, or die?**
3. Most of the letter **dismantles another rabbi's answer**, which branded those who complied **heretics, gentiles, wicked, unfit witnesses**, forbade their prayers, and cited **Christians** as proof.
4. **Duress vs. willingness**: the rabbi failed to make the basic distinction.
5. **Be careful with words**: prepare speech four times, writing far more.
6. **Speaking ill of Israel** cost **Moshe** (tzara'at), **Eliyahu**, **Yeshayahu** (the coal) and the accuser of **Yehoshua**, though those they spoke of sinned **willingly**.
7. **Rabbi Meir, Rabbi Eliezer**, Babylon, the Greek period: Jews who **outwardly complied** under duress were never condemned; **Hashem never abandons them**.

Coming Up

Next week: the last criticisms, then the Rambam's own answer: **five categories of martyrdom**, and what to do in practice.

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